

Nevertheless, the trailblazers took up the challenge to cast a web of railway lines across the country.

They surveyed terrains and adapted their technological know-how to meet the demands of the location and inhospitable weather, often at great human cost, such as in the construction of the high-inclined Bhore Ghat (see [Conquering The Ghats](#)) where about 25,000 people died due to accidents as well as diseases.

## **Birth of a blueprint**

It helped that there was a plan in place, penned by one of the most influential proponents of the railways in India, Governor-General [Lord Dalhousie](#). Written between 1850 and 1853, his Minutes proved to be invaluable. The first document, notes author Roopa Srinivasan in the introduction to *Our Indian Railway*, “developed a vision of railways as a single national ‘works’ or project.”

The second, a 216-page handwritten Minute, is what can perhaps be called the blueprint for the railways in India. It drove home the importance of laying lines across the country for commercial advancements and political and military purposes. There were “immeasurable advantages,” Dalhousie notes, while emphasizing the need for trunk routes. He proposed three in particular, which were favourable for engineering and ideal for future subordinate lines. The first was from Calcutta to Delhi and the North-West Frontier, the second from Bombay to Delhi, and the third from Madras towards the west coast. The railways would mushroom from these three hubs, encompassing the entire country.

He sent this Minute to the Court of Directors hoping that they would “resolve at once to engage in the introduction of a system of railways into this Indian Empire, upon a scale commensurate with the magnitude of the interests involved, and with the vast and various benefits, political, commercial, and social, which that great measure of public importance would unquestionably produce.” The Court finally agreed in August 1853.

## **Standardizing the widths**